The new-grad pipeline

Week 1, Lecture 2 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- The university recruiting calendar and when windows open
- Intern conversion: the highest-probability path to a new-grad offer
- What the new-grad market looks like in 2026
- Building a target list: reach, match, and safety tiers
- Tagging each company by side-door surface area

Part 1: the university recruiting calendar

The calendar that governs your search

- Large tech companies open new-grad applications in **August-September** for the following spring graduation
- Mid-size companies: **October-December**
- Startups and growth-stage companies: rolling, but peak hiring is **January-March**
- Many offers expire before graduation: you may sign in October for a May start

Missing the large-company window does not end your search. It changes your target list.

The intern conversion path

- Returning interns are the highest-conversion path to a new-grad offer
- Conversion rates at major tech companies: 60-80% of interns who want a return offer receive one
- The intern interview is already a de facto new-grad interview
- If you have a prior internship at a target company: the return application should be your first move, not your fallback

For students without a prior internship at a target: this is the path your competitors used. Build the equivalent signal another way.

What “new-grad vs. experienced” actually means

- Companies maintain two separate recruiting tracks with different criteria
- New-grad track: evaluated on school performance, internships, projects, and potential
- Experienced track: evaluated on prior employment, team scale, and scope of impact
- New grads compete only against other new grads on the new-grad track
- Applying to an experienced-hire role as a new grad is almost always the wrong move

Orosz (2025): the bar for what counts as “junior” has risen. The best new-grad candidates look more like experienced-hire candidates did five years ago.

Part 2: the target list

Three tiers, not one pile

- **Reach:** you would be thrilled and somewhat surprised to receive an offer
- **Match:** you are a plausible hire; the company hires people at your current profile level
- **Safety:** you are confident you can advance to offer stage and would accept

The mistake most students make: a list of 20 reach companies and 2 safeties. That is a lottery ticket strategy, not a pipeline.

What makes a company a reach vs. a match

- Reach: their typical new-grad hire has a credential (school, internship, project scale) you lack
- Match: their typical new-grad hire looks like you, or looks like you will after a strong final semester
- Safety: you know current or recent employees, the bar is documented, and you have met similar bars before

The same company can be a reach for one student and a match for another. Tier placement is about your profile, not the company’s brand.

Tagging by side-door surface area

For each company, answer these questions:

- **Referral:** do you know someone who works there or recently left?
- **Open source:** does the company sponsor or heavily use an OSS project you can contribute to?
- **Prior intern:** do you have a relationship from a previous internship cycle?
- **Public artifact:** is there a demo, write-up, or tool you could build that their engineers would find useful?

A company with no side-door tags deserves a harder look: portal-only applications to companies where you have no foothold are low-yield.

McKenzie’s framing: businesses hire to create value

- McKenzie (2011): engineers are hired to increase revenue or reduce costs
- The implication for your target list: what does each company actually need, and do you have evidence you can provide it?
- A target list with no answer to that question is a wish list
- The side-door tags are the concrete evidence. They show the company something before you apply.

> Engineers are hired to create business value, not to program things. Businesses do things for irrational and political reasons all the time, but in the main they converge on doing things which increase revenue or reduce costs.

<footer>Patrick McKenzie, “Don’t call yourself a programmer,” 2011</footer>

Building the list in practice

- Start with 40-50 names; cut to 30+ after tiering
- For each of your top 10: write one sentence explaining why that tier, and one concrete next action
- The next action should be completable in under an hour
- The list is a living document: you will re-tier companies as your profile improves

Take-aways

1. The university recruiting calendar has hard windows. Large-company applications open in August. Missing a window is recoverable, but only if you know it happened.
2. Intern conversion is the highest-probability path. If you have a prior relationship at a target company, activate it first.
3. A well-structured target list has realistic tiers: at least 8 companies at each of reach, match, and safety.
4. Side-door tagging turns a list of names into an action plan. Every company without a side-door tag is a portal-only bet; know that going in.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 1 reading covers the full funnel, side-door taxonomy, and target list construction in depth
- **Section (this week):** Bring any draft list you have; you will build to 30+ rows in the workshop
- **Lecture 1 (this week):** The four-stage funnel and where applicants die
- **HW 1 (out this week):** Resume and portfolio audit, due Week 3